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A Glance at New Persian Translations of the Middle Persian Texts

To Dariush Kargar (1953-2012)

Each single translation process, despite the fact that its theoretical description and classification stem from linguistics (cf. Jakobson 1989), must be understood as a phenomenon belonging to both literary and cultural studies. No wonder, then, that in order to establish a theoretical framework for the discussion regarding New Persian translations of the Middle Persian texts, it is necessary to begin by exploring the relations between two, namely the New Persian and Middle Persian literary and cultural traditions.

Historical sketch

A translation is a basic mechanism of awareness and a process of creating inter- or intra-cultural links not only between an original (initial) text and a translated (target) one, but even further, between two epochs, two social groups etc. In fact, this culture-oriented approach to a translation has a deeply functional, *skopos*-oriented¹ character and is patterned on Christiane Nord's statement:

A translation process is usually initiated by a customer or initiator, approaching a translator because they need a certain target text for a particular target addressee or receiver (Nord [1988] 2005, 6).

¹ Greek *skopos* "aim, target"; here: "translation aim, translation target" – a term put into academic circulation by Hans Vermeer and Katharina Reiss in the 1970s to denote an aim of functional translation activity.



For the first time, this functional approach was stressed by Katharina Reiss ([1971] 2000, 92ff.), who claims that it was an additional category to replace the classical criteria of Eugene Nida's equivalence-based critique of translation used for those texts that had two different original and translation targets (cf. Nord [1988] 2005, 5). In our case these two different translation targets result from two different linguistic and cultural-religious frameworks (Middle Persian-Zoroastrian vs. New Persian-Islamic) in which the same text used to exist (Middle Persian-Zoroastrian) and still exists (New Persian-Islamic). Consequently, Middle Persian-to-New Persian translations should be classified as Roman Jakobson's intra-linguistic (Middle Persian → New Persian) and inter-cultural (Zoroastrianism → Islam) at the same time (cf. Kłagisz 2011).

Persian literature is an old and rich part of the culture of the Persian-speaking Iranians. It is traditionally divided into at least three historical stages, called Old, Middle and New Persian on the grounds of three historical versions of the same language used in the respective periods. While the youngest stage is represented by an extraordinarily wealthy output belonging to a broad range of different literary genres, the oldest one is only a scanty collection of several royal cuneiform inscriptions, clay tablets, and seals of the Achæmenid dynasty (6th-4th BC).

The intermediate period known as Middle Persian (or Pahlavi²) lasted for more than ten centuries, from Alexander the Great's conquest of the Achæmenid empire (4th BC) until the Arab-Muslim invasion (7th AD), and even longer because some Middle Persian-composing (but non-speaking) scribes³ wrote down Zoroastrian texts a few centuries after the Sasanian kingdom had vanished:

In the linguistic and cultural sphere, the Middle Persian or Pahlavi language disappeared as a spoken tongue, and outside certain peripheral areas where Islam was late on penetrating, and outside the surviving Zoroastrian communities, it disappeared as a literary medium. Even among the Zoroastrian groups, knowledge of Pahlavi had sharply declined by the end of the tenth century; in 978 we have the composition of Kai Kā'us b. Kai Kusrau's *Zarādusht-nāma*, the first Zoroastrian text in New Persian (Bosworth 1978, 7-8).

² About etymology of the term *pahlavi* see e.g.: Tavadia (1956, 13-20).

³ Edward Sachau (1869, 5) quoted Niels Ludvig Westergaard's suggestion that Middle Persian had never been generally spoken by the Iranians, but only used to be a learned language of the Zoroastrian priests. Although we can submit this statement to discussion, we should admit that the language of Middle Persian literature did not change within the space of centuries and just before the collapse of the Sasanian empire was in fact a dead vernacular.



The varied, partially oral and written Middle Persian literature consisted of several asymmetrical parts: (1) numerous religious Zoroastrian writings (based on the *Avesta* and its commentary *Zand*), (2) few secular works (composed by e.g. *gōsāns*, i.e. minstrels) together with some translations of e.g. Indian popular stories, (3) scanty royal rock- and coin-inscriptions, (4) some Manichaean texts, and (5) single Christian translations of the *Psalms* (cf. West 1896-1904; Boyce 1968; Âmuzegâr, Tafazzoli 1382hš; Tafazzoli 1383hš). To this list we should add a rich folk tradition never put to pen, but crucial to both the aforementioned *gōsāns* and to the future New Persian poets, because it was like a treasure-trove full of motifs, stories, legends and heroes used before and after the Arab-Muslim invasion. The best example is a double image of Alexander the Great – negative in religious Zoroastrian writings, and positive in secular New Persian ones (cf. Maciuszak 1999, 303-304).

It is well accepted that the Arab-Muslim conquest had significant political, cultural, ethnic and linguistic impact on the Middle East. Nevertheless, it is hard to assume that only Islam wreaked havoc in the Iranian world, because, as Touraj Daryaee (2012, 13) writes: “At the dawn of the Islamic conquest, Ērānšahr (Domain of the Iranians) was on the verge of political chaos.” Admittedly, the conquerors brought Islam with them – a new attractive religion, more vital than the rigid Zoroastrianism represented by the clergymen who were more engaged in politics than in explaining and interpreting the true tenets of the religion.⁴

The gradual, irregular and multi-stage Islamisation of the Persian-speaking world demonstrated itself in many cultural aspects (cf. Choksy 1997, Niechciał 2013, 31-36):

(...) there was a violent change in the field of established religion and cult; the state church of Zoroastrianism was overthrown and the new faith of Islam introduced. Yet even here, it is impossible not to discern some elements of continuity. Islam could conceivably be viewed as a new, purified form of Zoroastrianism brought by the new prophet. Allāh and Iblis could be equated with Ahūra Mazda and Ahriman; there was a common belief in a creation story, in a resurrection, heaven and hell, and in angels and other spirits; both religions had the practices of worship and prayer and sacred texts; and the fatalistic aspects of Zurvanism, the form that Zoroastrianism took in the later Sāsānid period, was not unlike the

⁴ Niechciał (2013, 32) writes to the point that the problem of changing of the religion, and abandoning of Zoroastrianism for Islam is more complicated than it seems. It did not start after the invasion, but well before it. The late Sasanian elites’ attention was successfully attracted by other religions, first of all Nestorianism.



determinist views that became influential, if not universally acknowledged, in early Islam (Bosworth 1978, 7).

Changes which appeared radical at first, proved to be less trenchant as the old habits and traditional modes of thought returned in a new guise. (...) Popular religion, in particular, preserved many aspects of old religious thought and practices, albeit with different terminology. People continued to expect saviour who would rise one day, punish the wicked, and fill the world with justice. They continued traditional practices: visiting sacred shrines, revered the spirit of the dead, and knotted pieces of rags to the branches of sacred trees for boons. They avoided scattering their fallen teeth and pared nails for fear of contaminating the good earth, took great care in ritual purification, and uttered a benediction when candles or lamps were lighted. But now they called the Soshyant, their expected messiah, “Mahdi,” named the Chinvad Bridge to be crossed by the dead on the Day of Judgment “Pol-e Serāt,” and replaced Mashya and Masyāna with Adam and Eve (Yarshater 1988, 3-4).

Also, the development of the new Islamic reality was distinguished by different facts, e.g. the shifting of the main cultural centres from south-west to north-east Iran (where other Eastern Iranian languages were spoken at that time),⁵ replacing Middle Persian by its younger form – New Persian, as a means of literary expression (cf. Lazard 1971, 1975; Jeremiás 1984; Utas 2006), or partial replacement of Zoroastrian elements with Semito-Biblical ones.⁶ Despite all this, the Arab-Muslim conquest was not a surgical cut that simply divested the Iranians of their heritage.⁷ The Iranians, i.e. the Muslims and the Zoroastrians, took part in the creation of the Muslim caliphate

⁵ Few centuries later another invasion, this time of the Mongols coming from the North-East and wreaking havoc up to Baghdad, shifted the New Persian cultural centres from the Central Asia to the Iranian plateau once again.

⁶ Shortly after the Arab-Muslim conquest, the Iranians started to mix native Zoroastrian culture with a foreign, Semito-Biblical one. This is the reason why they started to perceive Zarathustra as Biblical Abraham (Haug 1878, 16), or Ġamšid as Solomon who allegedly built *Taxt-e Ġamšid* ‘the Throne of Ġamšid’, i.e. Persepolis, *Masġed-e Mâdar-e Soleymân* “the Mosque of Cyrus’ Mother,” i.e. the tomb of Cyrus, and *Taxt-e Soleymân* “the throne of Solomon,” i.e. a platform in Murqâb. Brown (1956, 112-113) suggested that the Zoroastrian clergymen intentionally allowed such combinations because they thought that this would help Zoroastrianism to be officially accepted in the Muslim empire just like Judaism and Christianity.

⁷ We can assume that if Zoroastrianism had won, Iran would have been Arabised, like some Christian communities in the Middle East that kept the religion and lost the language, but since the winner was Islam, Iran was Islamised but still kept its cultural identity independent of the Arabic one (cf. Danecki 2001, 150).



in different ways. They co-created the structure of the administration of the new empire, representing different conceptions of a theocratic state, that was an echo of the Iranian ideal of the royal authority. What is more, they enlivened the Islamic religiosity, making it complete with mysticism (cf. Kowalski 1935, 178ff.). By the 9th century, the Arab-Muslim and Persian traditions achieved a symbiosis, becoming a Persian-Muslim amalgam, where some native Persian elements were accepted, and other – rejected (cf. Bosworth 1978, 11; Gibb 1953).⁸ Later, this Persian-Muslim amalgam provided a base for another phenomenon – the Indo-Muslim culture on the Indian Subcontinent (cf. Kuczkiewicz-Fraś 2012).

This Persian-Muslim blend comes to the light in different aspects of everyday existence and cultural life; for example Arthur E. Christensen, deliberating on the nature of New Persian prosody, came to the conclusion that the Arabic influence had become less apparent:

Persian prosody is an adaptation of that of the Arabs: its terminology is Arabic, the metrical system is built upon quantity like that of Arabic poetry. The rhythm is reputed to be Arab origin. One thing strikes us: it is that of the most used metres in Arabic poetry – the *tawīl*, the *kamīl*, the *wāfir*, the *basīt*, the *mutaqārib*, the *sarī*; only the *mutaqārib* is in frequent use among the Persians, whilst the preferred metres of the latter, such as the *hazaj*, the *raml*, the *khafif*, are relatively scarce in Arabic, not to mention the *rubāʿī*, which is purely Persian (Christensen [1934] 1996, 25)

and suggested that the New Persian poetic forms were the results of the development of Middle Persian under the influence of Arabic rather than simple adaptations of Arabic prosody.

Persian-Muslim poets, having at their disposal two sets of sources – the oral and the written ones, used some old non-Muslim literary motifs and patterns, festooning them with new clothes, and successfully implementing them into New Persian-Muslim literary tradition (cf. Krasnowolska 2004, xv; Krasnowolska 2012; Lazard 1975, 606-611). This is a crucial thought for our further discussion about the conception of “exoticism/strangeness”

⁸ This process resembles to some degree a similar phenomenon of the Achæmenid art that combines different Middle Eastern artistic traditions. Although in this case a political message – all the conquered nations are members of one Achæmenid nation – is easy to find, it shows us the significant ability of the nascent Iranian culture to absorb elements from different traditions, digest them and build them into its own framework. Perhaps that is the reason why New Persian could become the *lingua franca* of the Middle East and South Asia.



vs. “familiarity/nativeness” in a translation context, and the possible usefulness of New Persian translations of Middle Persian works for Iranian writers of today.

Taking into consideration all the aforementioned views, we come to an important conclusion that New Persian literature is not a typical and natural product of the development of its Middle Persian predecessor, even if, as Ehsan Yarshater writes, “New Persian poets and writers owed much to the literature which had flourished in pre-Islamic Iran” (1988, 4). Taking into accounts the following facts: that the cultural centres were shifted to the peripheral areas of the Sasanian times, where other Iranian languages used to be spoken; that the Iranian society gradually changed their religion; and that this society had an astonishing ability to absorb foreign elements and to mingle them with its own, New Persian literature crossed its natural borders demarcated by the religion, becoming a universal whole shared by different ethnic and religious groups. In other words, New Persian literature must be understood as a phenomenon that belongs to both the Iranian Muslims and the Iranian *ağams* “non-Muslims,” e.g. Zoroastrians who use(d) New Persian in everyday communication.⁹

As I have already mentioned, the Arab-Muslim conquest was not a surgical cut that simply divested the Iranians of their heritage, because e.g. Middle Persian *gōsāns* continued their poetical activity as New Persian *xunyâgars* and *râmešgars*. The memory of the lost past still endured in people’s minds, but with the passage of time, due to, *inter alia*, the *Šâhnâme*, the memories of bygone days evolved, becoming more a (re)constructed mythology than historical reality.¹⁰ Consequently, the pre-Islamic past was perceived as “exotic” and “familiar” at the same time. No wonder that Daqiqi wrote that no-one would ever see the paradise if he did not follow the path of Zarathustra’s faith (cf. Shahbazi 1985, 509) and simultaneously confused the Hindus and the Zoroastrians, linking both with fire worship (cf. Schimmel 1975, 116).

This double perspective of the “exotic” and “familiar” past appeared due to the paramount factor of the Iranian post-Sasanian identity – the originally foreign Islam (for the last five hundred years, the Shia), and not the native Zo-

⁹ Here we touch a problem of the post-Sasanian Zoroastrian literature composed in New Persian in Iran (cf. e.g.: Sachau 1869; West 1896-1904, 122-129; de Menasce 1975) and in India (cf. e.g.: Williams 2009). I think that today we can speak about two independent Zoroastrian literary traditions – the almost non-existing Iranian one and the Indian one, composed first of all in English and being, in fact, a part of colonial and modern Indian literature.

¹⁰ The process of gradual mythologisation of the past had started long before the Arab-Muslim conquest, but the invasion helped in strengthening it.



roastrianism of smaller and diminishing communities that still exist in Yazd, Kerman or Tehran:

The Islamisation of Persia brought about such deep and enduring transformation in the life and culture of the country that some Persians began to regard their pre-Islamic past as a pagan era which ended with the fall of the Sasanian empire (Yarshater 1988, 3).¹¹

Islam has become an integral part of the contemporary Iranian identity and ethnicity which are linked primarily with the religion rather than with the language. From that point of view, we come to the bizarre conclusion that Middle Persian literature, being non-Islamic, must be understood as a foreign, while New Persian one (no matter Islamic or Zoroastrian), partially based on Middle Persian, but enmeshed with Islam,¹² is perceived as native. A pertinent question arises here: How does this conception affect the translations of Middle Persian literature?

Two stages/types of translation

First of all, we must remember that, looking at the phenomenon of translation of Middle Persian texts into New Persian, we can easily distinguish two stages and two types of such translation activity. The first stage (and type) is closely connected with the aforementioned Arab-Muslim conquest, because one of its results was the meaningful activity of the Zoroastrian clergymen-scribes as well as some Muslim Arabic- and New Persian-speaking historians and researchers interested in the culture, history or religion(s) of pre-Islamic Iran (cf. West 1878, 14-16).

¹¹ I see here some substantial similarities between Polish and Iranian perception of the past, pre-Christian and pre-Islamic respectively. Mechanisms that helped Polish romantic philosophers like Bogusław F. Trentowski and Persian poets like Abolqasem Ferdousi to create their visions of these distant pasts were different, but the political atmosphere of their times was similar – neither Poland, nor Iran existed as independent states; Poland had been divided between its three neighbouring countries, and Iran was divided into a few kingdoms fighting against each other. Maria Janion (2007), writing about the Polish pre-Christian past and its picture based on mythology and mythologised facts rather than on history, unknowingly prompts us to use her scientific tools to research the same phenomenon on the Iranian ground. Christianity and Islam (and, in addition, the language) were the strongest binders of the Polish and Iranian national identities, because the missionaries' activity cut off the pagan past from the "healthy" present (cf. Kłagisz 2009, 259-260).

¹² We can find some Islamic elements also in New Persian Zoroastrian writings, like in the story of Anūšīrvān where also Ali appears as one of the main heroes (cf. Sachau 1869, 30-36).





The Zoroastrian priests tried to save their own religion, which was threatened by several factors, like conversion to Islam and the dislike (or even enmity) of the Muslims. Some of the Islamic theologians did not recognise Zoroastrianism as a monotheistic religion, but as a pagan one, and consequently refused the Zoroastrians (labelled with the contemptuous term *zandīq* or *kâfer*) to be called *ahl-e ketâb* in contrast to the Jews or the Christians. Nevertheless, there were still a few Muslim historians, like Tâğaddīn Abū'l-Fath Mohammad ebne Abdolkarīm aš-Šahrastānī (12th AD), who in his *Ketâb al-melal va'n-nehal* rated the Zoroastrians among the same group as the Jews and the Christians. Meanwhile, some Zoroastrian clergymen tried to convince their Muslim counterparts that they, too, have at their disposal a sacred book – the *Avesta*, and that they could be equal partners in such theological discussions as the dispute of Ādurfarnbag with the apostate Zoroastrian named Abālīšt in the presence of Caliph Ma'cūn (cf. Chacha 1936, 46).

The Zoroastrian scribes, trying to collect as many religious texts as it was possible at that time, and passing them on to the next generations, did not place the main emphasis on the aesthetic value of the sacred writings. They made only a small attempt to research their own religion. In the 9th century Mardānfarrox-ī Ōhrmazddādān wrote the *Škand-Gumānīg Wizār*, where he put Zoroastrianism and other religions like Islam, Judaism, Christianity and Manichæism together, simply eulogizing Zoroastrianism and condemning others (cf. West [2005] 1885, 115-251).

This activity of Zoroastrian clergymen was accompanied by the parallel activity of some Muslim Arabic- and New Persian-speaking historians, for instance the neophyte Rōzbeh better known as ibn al-Muqaffa^c. It was a part of larger scientific activity of the very first Muslim scholars, who translated some ancient Greek or Indian philosophical or scientific works into Arabic. Some of the texts prepared by them were later used by native New Persian-speaking authors like Bahā'addīn Mohammad ebne Esfandiyār, who translated the Arabic translation of a Middle Persian letter written by the high Sasanian priest Tōsar to Gošnāsp, an administrator of the northern province Tabaristān (cf. Boyce 1968).

What is more important, the whole process was in many cases beneficial to the Persian culture. It helped to preserve a part of its rich literary heritage, although “Middle Persian literature, the greater part of which, being Zoroastrian, vanished like snow in the heat of the Islamic summer” (Boyce 1968, 2). Paraphrasing the title of Stanisław Barańczak's book *Ocalone w tłumaczeniu*, i.e. *Saved in translation*, we may say that ibn al-Muqaffa^c, ebne Esfandiyār and others saved in their translations and adap-





tations some elements of the Iranian identity, transferring them to the next generations.¹³

One of the reasons why the very first Iranian Muslims did that, was the fact, that they looked for their cultural roots in a partly mythicised history of the ancient Iranian rulers.¹⁴ Today's interest in the pre-Islamic tradition, culture and literature is, so to speak, a repetition of that phenomenon observed in the first Islamic centuries in Iran. It refers to the splendour and magnificence of ancient Iran, about which the Iranians have some blurred and vague conception.

The second stage is connected with nationalistic modern Iranian ideas propagated by the Pahlavi dynasty in the 20th century. These ideas referred to the glorious past and the might of the Achæmenid house. This stage is connected also with the academic interest of some Western (and, secondarily, Parsi) researchers in the Iranians' ancient and pre-Islamic history, culture, and first of all, their religion. The 19th and 20th centuries were the time of intensive scientific activity for Parsi researchers, translators and commentators, for instance Kharshedji Rustomji Cama, Sir Jivanji J. Modi and Behramgore Tehmurasp Anklesaria who, being inspired by their European counterparts, took an active interest in their own religion, one hundred years after Abraham Hyacinthe Anquetil-Duperron published his translation of the *Avesta*. At the beginning, the Parsis travelled to Iran, looking for ancient texts and religious knowledge, but later the Iranian Zoroastrians used the Parsis' output to create their own texts.

The second type of New Persian translation prepared by such scholars as Rahim Afifi, Ahmad Tafazzoli or Žâlê Âmuzegâr is of scientific character, and does not have a long or reach tradition. The very first New Persian translations of ancient texts, mostly the *Avesta*, appeared just in the beginning of the

¹³ The problem that I would not like to discuss here is the question whether Middle Persian translations can be used by modern New Persian-speaking writers, or not. It seems that old pre-Islamic motifs were adapted just at the time of the formation of classical literature. That means that they are not perceived by today's writers as attractive, and such plays as Erslân Puryâs *Âraš-e tirandâz* – the history of the archer Âraš who demarcated the border between Iran and Turan, Âqâ-Nağafi Qučâni's novel *Siyâhat-e qarb*, Zeynolâbedin Marağê's *Siyâtanâme-ye Ebrâhim-beg* or Bahrâm Beyzâyi's *Gozâreš-e Ardâ Virâf* – all inspired by the Middle Persian *La Divina Commedia*, are exceptions. Surprisingly, interest in the historical novel appeared in Iran under the influence of European literatures and their translations into New Persian. Such works like Abbâs Âryân Pur-e Kâšâni's *Arus-e Medi* or Mohammad Ali Xalili's *Doxtar-e Kuroš* refer to the pre-Islamic past only with their plots, not because they refer to old texts (cf. Machalski 1952).

¹⁴ It is not a new phenomenon in the Persian culture: the Sasanians did the same, adapting and mingling some very old myths and legends inherited from the Parthians with historical events only to build their identity and to prove their right to the Iranian crown.





20th century, namely in 1928, when Ebrâhim Pur-e Dâvud published the first volume of his translation of the *Yašt* hymns in Mumbai. For the very long time Ebrâhim Pur-e Dâvud was the only Iranian researcher of the *Avesta*, but now his work is continued by Ġalil Dustxâh and Hâšem Razi. Interestingly, the second modern Iranian researcher of the pre-Islamic past was Sâdeq Hedâyat, a famous writer and dissenter, who spent a few years among the Indian Zoroastrians in Mumbai, working with Behramgore Tehmurasp Anklesaria. He published four translations: *Goğaste Abâliš* (1940), *Kârnâme-ye Ardašir-e-Pâpakân* (1943), *Zand-e Vohuman Yasn* (1944), and *Âmadan-e šâh Bahrâm-e Varġâvand* (1945). What is more, some of the original Zoroastrian motifs appeared also in his novels and short stories.

Both stages, belonging to two literary periods, are aimed at two groups of readers, and have two *Übersetzungszwecke*, i.e. translation targets. During the first stage mostly functional translations (and adaptations) prepared by the *mōbēds* dominated. The readers of those translations-adaptations were firstly the Iranian Zoroastrians, and secondly the Iranian Muslims. The Zoroastrians treated them both as *belles-lettres* and religious works, while for the Muslims they did not have any religious significance. This stage started some time after the Arab-Muslim conquest, and lasted for at least six or seven centuries, until the 17th century AD.

During the second stage, more active are the Muslim historians and researchers (mostly linguists), who make use of modern Western scientific methods in preparing their own translations, which are more of a scientific than of a literary character. Contrary to the readers of the *mōbēds*' works, the readers of modern ones are firstly the Iranian Muslims, and secondly the Iranian Zoroastrians:

Stage	First	Second
Character	Functional translation	Scientific translation
Environment	Zoroastrian priests	Muslim scholars
Time frame	10 th /13 th -17 th AD	Since the early 20 th AD

but, both stages have something in common – an impulse to translate came from outside in the shape of Islam and of some Western scholars interested in Zoroastrianism.

As I have already mentioned, during the very first centuries after the advent of Islam in *Ērānšahr*, a part of Middle Persian texts was promptly written down, quickly copied, or frantically re-written by the *mōbēds*, who were worried with the gradual Islamization of the originally Zoroastrian lands. At that time, Middle Persian was no longer a language commonly used and understood by the members of New Persian-speaking Zoroastrian communities. For





this reason some of the priests, like Zartošt Bahram Paždu or Mazubân, were aware of an unavoidable necessity of changing the literary vernacular from Middle Persian to New Persian. It was the only way to keep the communication with their kinsmen open:

na-dârad bedin xat(t) kas-i dastgâh / be-tarsam ke gardad be yek rah tabâh
(*Adrâ-Virâf-nâme-ye manzum* 1343hš, 12).

No one has the key to this script / I am afraid that it will totally disappear
(translation – M.K.).

Quelle langue persane?

Nowadays, the Iranian translators and researchers face an uphill task. As Barbara Mękarska (2000, 197) questions: “*De quelle langue persane s’agit-il dans les traductions des langues anciennes qui ont été accomplies dans les dernières 60-70 ans?*” Should it be Classical New Persian,¹⁵ or maybe its modern form? This question is not easy to answer, because the language of New Persian Zoroastrian literature is by no means purely classical, but contains some words that cannot be found in e.g. Steingass’ dictionary.¹⁶ Should the language thus reflect the historical distance between the original text and its translated “peer”? Or, just the opposite, it should help the translator to bridge the gap between two historical and cultural epochs? Both questions refer to the problem emphasised by Renata Czekalska and Halina Marlewicz (2002, 224), who query whether or not a transition from one culture to another is possible in general. In our case, there is also the problem of a potential distortion of the message ingrained in the original text. The most interesting are those pre-Islamic vs. Islamic cultural differences that influence the process of translation. This culture-oriented aspect of translation has been emphasised by Justa Holz-Mänttâri (Nord 2005a, 30-31), who replaces the traditional term “translation” with a new one – “intercultural cooperation.” By replacing “translation” with “intercultural cooperation,” she wants to purify the process from various unconsciously attributed traditional conceptions and expectations towards the word.

Getting back to the language of New Persian translations, I should point at the artificial archaization of their language that consists not only of the usage

¹⁵ For the discussion of what Classical Persian is, see e.g.: Azarnouche (2002), Lazard (1963), Paul (2002).

¹⁶ Most of these words are Zoroastrian religious terms, but also some lexemes to be found in the language of the Iranian Zoroastrians.





of Middle Persian and classical lexemes no longer understood by the modern reader, but also of the accumulation of New Persian neologisms. All this contributes to providing the readers with a linguistically and semantically dense text. They must first crack the tough shell of the language to reach the meaning which may still be partially unfamiliar to them. At the beginning of my research, I suggested that such translation methods impress the readers but, in fact, severely bore them (cf. Kłagisz 2009, 253-254; 2008); at the same time it cannot be denied that a translator cannot avoid using loanwords, calques and neologisms. They may raise a sort of a barrier, but reading requires a lot of effort and involvement on the part of the readers.

At the first glance, we might think that the Zoroastrian priests simply “poured” the same Zoroastrian content into a new New Persian literary form because the only thing that had changed was the language. The problem is that they did not simply translate the texts, but often adapted them, changing and modernising their plots or structures (cf. Sachau 1869, 8), unconsciously following Yury Tynyanov’s suggestion that every translation is of a more complicated nature. It is not a simple transfer of a literary plot from one language to another, because otherwise we would have to agree that something like translation “fidelity” really does exist.¹⁷ Roman Jakobson (1989) emphasised that the aesthetic values of the language of the text are only partially dependent on its linguistic aspects. In other words, it is impossible to separate the content from its form because, as Ferdinand de Saussure stated, the *signifier* (*signifiant*) and the *signified* (*signifié*) cannot be understood as two separate entities but rather as a mapping from significant differences from sound to potential differential denotation. Consequently, the form of the text and its content are inseparably bound to each other, just like two sides of the same page of a single sheet of paper. Creating a new form for “the same” text, we create, in fact, its new version, called a translation or an adaptation, more or less similar but never the same (sic!). These remarks refer to all kinds of New Persian translations of Middle Persian texts. A case in point is Zartošt Bahram Paždu’s New Persian version of the *Ardā Wirāz Nāmag*, which varies significantly from the original. It is a poetic adaptation adjusted to the literary taste of the New Persian-speaking Zoroastrians who had grown up listening to New Persian poetry rather than to Middle Persian one.¹⁸

¹⁷ Regarding translation fidelity as a myth see: Lipiński (2004, 78).

¹⁸ The translations of Zoroastrian literature remind us, to some degree, of the translations of the *Bible* into New Persian, because they fulfil, first of all, an informative function about the “Other” culture. Of course, this tradition is not similar to the Polish tradition of translating the *Bible*, because in this case it exists between an artistic translation and a theological message. Regarding Persian translations of the *Bible* for the Iranian Christians see: Rzepka (2012).





Today, a translator, transferring a Middle Persian text into the framework of New Persian language (and literature), sets himself a target, i.e. an attempt to bring that unusual part of the Persian literary heritage closer to the contemporary reader who does not have any access to this heritage because he does not know either the language of the original text or its alphabet. The language – Middle Persian, the alphabets – modified Aramaic ones, and the religion – Zoroastrianism, create three obstacles that must be overcome by the Iranian scholar-translator. Consequently, he often skips the question of aesthetic values of his work, but the lack of them is closely connected with two other things:

1. A different approach to aesthetics of translation, and
2. Another concept of a proper literary form.

We touch here such phenomena as “exoticism” and “familiarity.” The presence of two opposing concepts: ‘exoticism/strangeness’ and ‘familiarity/native-ness’, discussed by Anton Popovič (1971), at the level of artistic expression, to which undoubtedly literary translation belongs, causes a serious problem of expectations of the recipient of the translated text, who looks at the text in terms of “my-own” or “not-my-own.”¹⁹

Anton Popovič claimed that the reader expects “otherness” from the translation he reads, but this alienation cannot affect the structure of the text. His expectations are, therefore, incompatible with the expectations of the recipient of the original text, who looks for “familiarity” rather than strangeness. It also means that although a translator uses “his-own” language, at the same time his work – a translated text – does not belong to “his-own” literary tradition. Critics are fond of accusing translators of awkwardness, of praising the individual features of the author, forgetting that they deal with a translation, not with an original text, and even if the translated text speaks “their-own” vernacular and becomes a part of “their-own” literature, it will always be labelled as “not-their-own,” for the following two reasons:

1. Each translation blends into its new literary family to a variable extent; for instance, *Harry Potter* will always be recognised as English, while *Winnie the Pooh* in its marvellous Polish version by Irena Tuwim, entitled *Kubuś Puchatek*, seems to be more Polish than English.

¹⁹ I reject the conception of a translation which should be like a see-through glass. There is a significant difference between the original and translated text; the first one is created, while the second one combines the re-creation of the original text and creation of the translated one. See: Legeżyńska (1997).



The category of “otherness” is purely subjective, and depends on the reader’s attitude only. We expect “otherness” from Andrzej Polkowski’s translation of *Harry Potter*, but we do not expect it from Irena Tuwim’s translation of *Winnie the Pooh*.²⁰

- 2 “My-own” literature is characterised by Roland Barthes’ *dejà lu*, which means that each single literary work is nothing more than a compilation of thousands of quotations stemming from culture. For contemporary Iranian readers, Middle Persian texts transferred into New Persian seem to be exotic because most of the preserved Middle Persian texts are of a strongly religious character. It means that below the first level, i.e. the level of the language, the readers can hardly find such *dejà lu* elements that would be found in the *Šâhnâme*, in the *Vis-o-Ramin* and other classical works, as well as in some modern texts referring to the past. This is mostly because such non-religious motifs existed predominantly in oral literature, rather than in the written one.

We touch here also the second phenomenon – another concept of a proper literary form which I would place somewhere between “*mimesis*” and “quotation.” The late Marek Smurzyński (2000, 457) suggested that in the case of New Persian translations we should talk not about *mimesis*, but rather about a quotation. Marek Smurzyński borrowed this concept from Edward Balcerzan (1985), and, also following Balcerzan, linked it with intertextuality. Since a quotation is defined by different rules than *mimesis* understood as imitation, representation, mimicry, non-sensuous similarity, act of resembling, or act of expression, we do not describe a translation using the philosophical and literary discourse that we would link to the text-product of the creative interpretation. Additionally, the quotation does not force the creation of any meta-language, and does not provide the recipient the feeling that the text is “tame.” As the translation act becomes a larger model, the act does not fit, according to Marek Smurzyński, in the development by national and individualistic European cultural standards of the “Other’s” behaviour. This issue is also connected with other linguistic, literary and translation techniques and ways of focusing the home recipient on the original text.

One of the consequences of translation understood in this way is a different perception of aesthetic values present in the translated text, as well as the free association of the “Other,” that is “not-my-own,” without any need for a rational perception of the source. The text does not have to be open, or to open

²⁰ That is why Monika Adamczyk-Grabowska’s translation, although closer to the English original, has been rejected by the Polish fans of *Winnie the Pooh*.



itself to the readers; quite the reverse, it may be hermetic, and yet still attractive at the same time. Marek Smurzyński's opinion brings to mind one of the three kinds of translation defined by Anton Popovič – discovering a new style and enrichment of the native literary phenomenon.

Translations prepared by the representatives of the first group of translators consist in the adaptation of a style typical for a receiving culture; this means absorbing the poetry of original text by the poetry of the target language. Many of the translation methods, solutions, propositions and suggestions made by today's translators can be or even should be classified as stylistically unmarked and an "elimination of the language translation."

I think that in accepting such notions of openness of Iranian literature toward translations of Middle Persian works, we go back to the already mentioned, rather startling thesis that the Iranians perceive their own literary works, the pre-Islamic texts, just as "exotic." But this is a problem of how to define properly such terms as 'identity' ("local, historical, imagined and collective identity and also self-identity," Keshmirshakan 2010, 489) and 'exoticism' ("which appears inevitably related to the first," Keshmirshakan 2010, 489) as two opposing but enmeshing characteristics of the Middle Persian translated works. Can their identity be based on local, historical and cultural continuity? What about their exoticism which, according to Barbara Mękarska, is clearly expected by the reader? The reader expects that a translation he is reading will not blend into his familiar reality, but will keep some of its strangeness. This means that there is a difference between the older and the newer New Persian translations:

Stage	First	Second
Character	Functional translation, adaptation and mimesis, should be familiar	Scientific translation, translation and quotation, should be exotic
Environment	Zoroastrian priests	Muslim scholars
Time frame	10 th /13 th -17 th AD	Since the early 20 th AD

Instead of conclusions

As Barbara Mękarska (2000, 199) points out, modern Iranian intellectuals, researchers, linguists and translators are looking more closely at their own literary past. Very often the still unsung and somewhat forgotten literary output of the pre-Islamic period becomes the main topic of their works. Taking





into consideration the fact that some translations published before 1979 are reprinted and new translations are appearing in the market, we might suggest that they are in demand, despite their rather hermetic (and boring) language, as well as the “unfamiliar” content. On other hand, this sort of translations comes into being on the fringe, if not outside of the modern New Persian literature; quite often these are rather scholarly studies than literary works. Despite this fact, today’s translations-adaptations of Middle Persian texts enter partly into the aforementioned increased activity of Zoroastrian clergymen-scribes and copyists and Arabic-/New Persian-speaking Muslim translators. The crucial difference between the first and the second type of translations is their audience – not a Zoroastrian one, but a Muslim one.





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